

ONE **SPAWNING** FEMALE
SEA LAMPREY MAY LAY
UP TO **300,000 EGGS**

THE **LENGTH** OF
A **SEA LAMPREY**
CAN BE UP TO

4 FT (1.2 M)

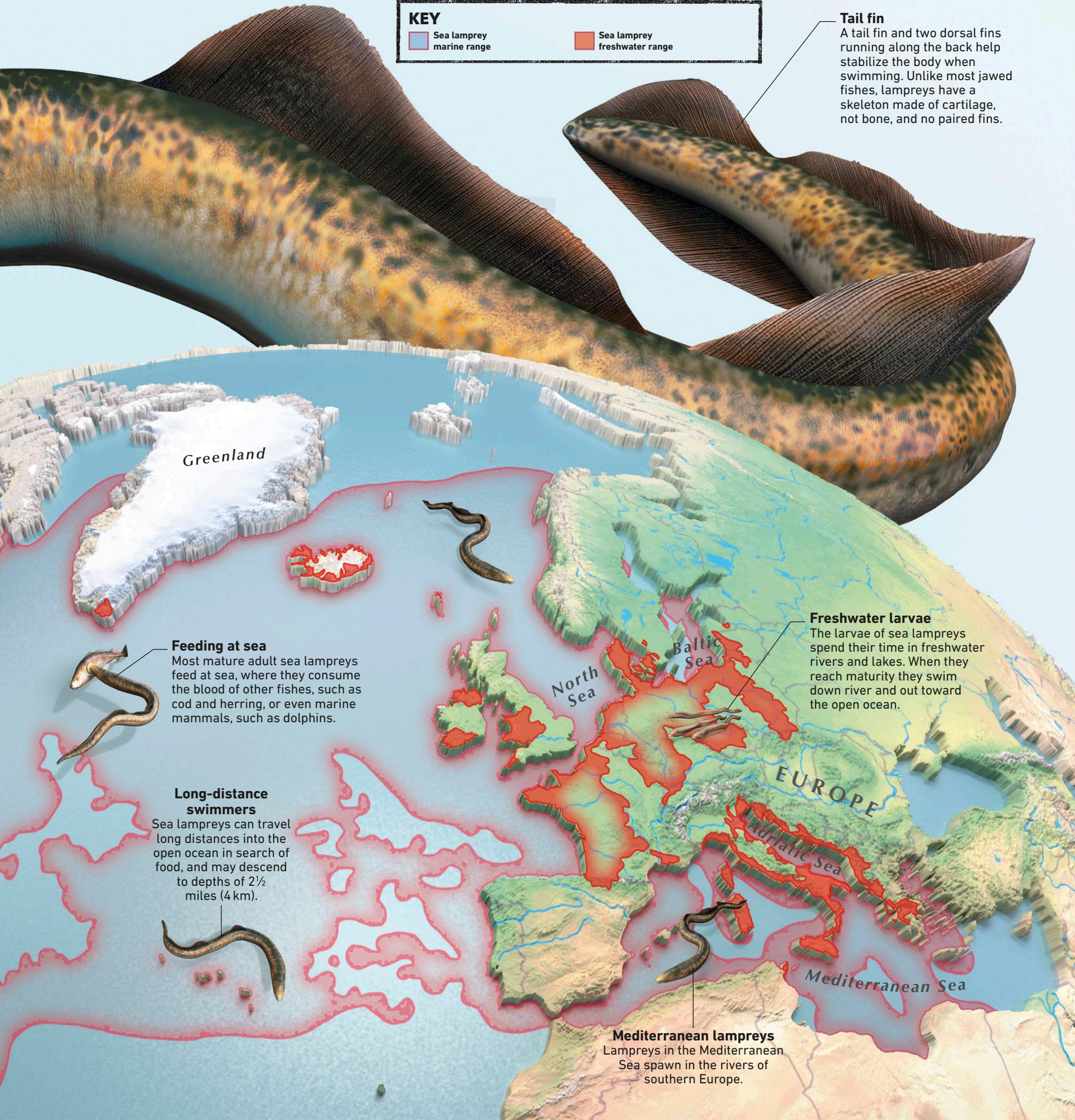
KEY

Sea lamprey
marine range

Sea lamprey
freshwater range

Tail fin

A tail fin and two dorsal fins running along the back help stabilize the body when swimming. Unlike most jawed fishes, lampreys have a skeleton made of cartilage, not bone, and no paired fins.



Feeding at sea

Most mature adult sea lampreys feed at sea, where they consume the blood of other fishes, such as cod and herring, or even marine mammals, such as dolphins.

Long-distance swimmers

Sea lampreys can travel long distances into the open ocean in search of food, and may descend to depths of 2½ miles (4 km).

Freshwater larvae

The larvae of sea lampreys spend their time in freshwater rivers and lakes. When they reach maturity they swim down river and out toward the open ocean.

Mediterranean lampreys

Lampreys in the Mediterranean Sea spawn in the rivers of southern Europe.